
**Unit 1, Option C,
Topic C5:
Commerce
and Imperial
Expansion,
c1815-70**

The focus of this topic is on imperial expansion during the heyday of British global power and economic primacy. Since the focus of this unit is on broad themes, questions will not be set which concentrate exclusively on depth of knowledge, for example about one particular individual or event, other than those which are specifically listed in the content bullet points. Students will, however, be expected to demonstrate their understanding of the themes defined in the content bullet points by the selection and deployment of relevant information as exemplification.

Collectively, the four content bullet points offer a framework for understanding the themes of the exercise of imperial power and the challenges and resistance to that power. Bullet points cannot be taken in complete isolation from one another and students should develop an appreciation of links between them. For example a question on the role of the navy in expanding British trade would call upon bullet point 3 and the Royal Navy's importance in forcing China to open its commercial doors more widely and bullet point 4 which concerns the crucial role of the Royal Navy in the suppression of piracy worldwide.

The first bullet point relates to the situation in 1815 and students should understand not only the territorial gains, confirmed in 1815, but also the expansion of manufacturing in the United Kingdom and Britain's increasing primacy in world commerce. They should be aware of the strategic significance of territories gained, such as Malta and the Cape, and the massive size of the Royal Navy by the end of the years of conflict which, together with control of a network of bases, gave Britain command of the world's oceans. The relative power of ships of war in this period by comparison with land forces gave Britain the advantage in the projection of force worldwide. Students should understand and be able to illustrate and explain the extent of Britain's influence.

The second bullet point relates to economics of empire in this period. Students should understand the importance of parts of the empire as markets for British manufacturers, such as cottons to the Indian sub-continent, and the crucial role of the Empire as suppliers of raw materials and food, such as sugar from the West Indies. They should also be aware of the prime importance of areas outside formal political control, such as the southern states of the USA, as suppliers of raw cotton for the great industry in Lancashire. Students should be aware of the dynamics of economic change involving both growth and decline, for example the rapid growth of British manufacturing predominance and the decline of manufacturing in India.

The third bullet point relates to the important distinction between actual political control, as in much of the Indian sub-continent, and the extensive informal influence exercised by Britain in areas such as China and South America. Students should understand something of the growing British influence in China where both forms of influence existed: formal in Hong Kong from 1842 and informal in Shanghai. They should also understand and be able to illustrate the importance of naval power in expanding formal and exercising informal influence, the wars against China in 1839-42 and 1856-60 being excellent examples.

The fourth bullet point relates to the moral dimension of imperial expansion in these years. Students should be aware of the role of the Royal Navy in suppressing piracy and in inhibiting the slave trade and the abolition of slavery within the Empire in 1833. They should be aware of the role of missionaries and the connection of Christian idealism with the belief in the virtue of imperial control and expansion.
